ECON1020

Country Report Instruction (total number of pages: 10)

Assessment Task	Country Report
Group or Individual	Individual
Weighting	35% (100 marks reweighted to 35%)
Word Limit	1200 ± 100 words
DUE DATE	1.00 pm Thursday 5th September
Marking Guide (Rubric)	Blackboard > Assessment > Country Report > Rubric
Submission	Turnitin via course BB site (further guidance provided below). The submission title (which is different from the file name) must be of the following format: Allocated Country First Name Surname (e.g., Norway Pimrak Pakdeethai)
Academic Integrity	UQ has strict rules against cheating, including "colluding with other students on individual assessment items". You must read and be familiar with these rules (PPL 3.60.04 Student Integrity and Misconduct).
Acknowledgement	We would like to acknowledge the contribution of Jackie Chin, Strategist, Dynamic Asset Allocation at Future Fund, BEcon (Hons) 2005, in the development of this report assignment.

CONTEXT

A multinational company is considering investing in the country that you have been allocated. If the macroeconomic environment of the country is deemed favourable compared to alternative destinations, then the company will proceed to look for specific investment projects. However, you are not provided with any information regarding potential investment projects for commercial confidentiality reasons.

YOUR TASKS

As independent an economic consultant, you are hired by this company to:

a) provide an economic profile for the country; and
b) benchmark its performance against some other potential destination countries.

In doing so, you will deliver a structured ***Country Report***, which includes the following illustrative features:

- ☐ Up to three (3) figures (diagrams, graphs or tables) in total. Here, you can use a mixture of diagrams, graphs and tables provided the total number is no more than 3.
- ☐ You can include more than one variable in a graph or table.
- ☐ You must produce your figures, rather than cut and paste from some sources. You must keep a copy of the file that you use to create your figures as you could be asked to provide it as proof that those figures are your work.
- ☐ You can use direct quotes provided the total number of quoted words sums to 20 words or less in the whole of the report. This rule is intended to prevent students from over-relying on direct quotes without critically analysing the content of the source.

WARNING: This assessment task evaluates students' abilities, skills and knowledge without the aid of Artificial Intelligence (AI) such as ChatGPT. Students are advised that the use of AI technologies to develop responses is **strictly prohibited** and may constitute **student misconduct** under the Student Code of Conduct.

However, you are allowed to use proofreading software, such as Grammarly (www.grammarly.com), to help you proofread your report.

COUNTRY ALLOCATION

The country you must use for this report is based on the ***last digit of your student number***: For example, if your student number is *44194356*, then you need to work on country number 6 – New Zealand.

Last digit	**Country**
0	Canada
1	United Kingdom
2	South Korea
3	Switzerland
4	Japan
5	Norway
6	New Zealand
7	Sweden
8	Italy
9	Singapore

PLEASE NOTE: The number in your student email address (e.g., S4419435) is not your student number: it misses the last digit (i.e. 6 in this example). A penalty will be applied if you fail to follow the country allocation rules.

Penalty Rates

LATE SUBMISSION:

- When an extension has not been previously approved, a penalty of 10 marks (out of 100) will be deducted for every 24-hour block up to 7 calendar days, at which point any submission will not receive any marks. That is:
  - 10 marks penalty if submitted within 24 hours after the deadline
  - 20 marks penalty if submitted between 24 to 48 hours after the deadline
  - …
  - 60 marks penalty if submitted between 120 to 144 hours after the deadline
  - 70 marks penalty if submitted between 144 to 168 hours after the deadline
  - After 168 hours, a zero mark will be given.

HIGH TURNITIN SIMILARITY INDEX VALUE:

- 8-10: as much as 5 marks (out of 100) may be deducted
- 11-15: as much as 10 marks (out of 100) may be deducted
- 16-20: as much as 15 marks (out of 100) may be deducted
- > 20: as much as 30 or more marks (out of 100) may be deducted.

Besides mark deduction, cases of alleged plagiarism will be reported to the School's Integrity Officer for investigation following the University's policy.

Similarity index values change slightly over time as Turnitin continuously add new materials to its database. The best strategy is to keep your similarity index value sufficiently low, e.g., below 5, so that even though it goes up a little bit after submission it will not exceed 7.

You are given a **buffer of 7** for the **Similarity Index Value** to cover some unavoidable similarities. In addition, anything on the template and references is excluded from the index, and Turnitin will ignore a small amount of unavoidable similarity.

COPYING FIGURES:

- For each copied figure (diagrams, graphs, or tables): 15 marks (out of 100) will be deducted.
- The penalty remains the same even if references are provided for the copied figures.
- You must keep a copy of the file that you use to create your figures as you could be asked to provide it as proof that those figures are your own work.

WRONG COUNTRY: 15 marks (out of 100) will be deducted.

OMITTING THE COVER SHEET:

- Omitting the whole cover sheet: 10 marks (out of 100) will be deducted.
- Omitting some parts of the cover sheet: 5 marks (out of 100) will be deducted.

EXCEEDING THE WORDCOUNT LIMIT (1200 ± 100):

- 5 marks for every 50 words exceeding 1300.
- E.g., 5 marks for 1308; 10 marks for 1375 etc.
- No penalty for less than 1100 words. But students may lose marks for insufficient content.

WRONG SUBMISSION TITLE STRUCTURE: 10 marks (out of 100) will be deducted.

- The submission title is not the same as the file name.
- You will be asked to provide a submission title when you upload your file.
- What we require is a correct submission title structure because the marker identifies your submission based on the submission title, not the file name.

REPORT STRUCTURE

1. **Macroeconomic Performance (~550 words)**

   a. Assess the macroeconomic performance of your country based on macroeconomic indicators covered in Topics 1-4 of this course, e.g., GDP per capita, inflation, unemployment etc., for 5-10 years up to 2018.

   b. Explain how these indicators are related to each other in the context of your country using theories and concepts covered in the course.

   c. Explain what factors, including economic policies, are driving these indicators.

2. **Benchmarking (~450 words)**

   a. Select a country as a benchmark to evaluate your country's macroeconomic performance. Explain the reasons for your selection and potential limitations.

   b. How does your country's macroeconomy perform compared to the benchmark country? Explain the reasons for any differences.

   c. Which country will be a more preferred investment destination and why?

3. **Reflection (~200 words)**

   a. Which aspect(s) of the Country Report did you find most difficult and why?

   b. How did you overcome those difficulties?

   c. What advice and suggestion(s) can you give to your future fellow students about completing the Country Report?

4. **References**

   References and citations must be in the APA 7th style.

PLEASE NOTE: You must **use the report template** on Blackboard > Assessment > Country Report > Report Template.

The **formatting requirements** are:

- Font type: Arial
- Font size: 11
- Line space: 1.15
- 1200 ± 100 words

You must include **the cover sheet** (in the template) in your submission.

The **wordcount** does not include:

- the coversheet
- the references
- section headings
- figures
- figure headings
- short notes underneath figures, e.g., Source: WDI (2021).

The **wordcount** includes in-text citations.

Tips for Section 1 Macroeconomics Performance:

- ✓ The 550 word 'limit' for this section is a guide only. You can write more or less than 550, as long as your total wordcount is within 1200 ± 100. (The same principle applies to other sections.)
- ✓ 5-10 years up to 2018 means that your report should cover at least 2013-2018 but can be as extensive as 2008-2018.
- ✓ Consider a range of macroeconomic indicators rather than just one or two indicators.
- ✓ Typically, graphs have stronger visual impacts than tables.
- ✓ If you provide a figure (diagram, graph, table), make sure that you explain/discuss it. Readers (i.e., markers) have no obligation to interpret it for you.
- ✓ For part (b), Think about what you have learnt in the course about how the change in one indicator is linked to the changes in some other indicators. Your report is expected to provide such a discussion.
- ✓ There is no need to explain the concepts and definitions of commonly used macroeconomic indicators (e.g., 'GDP stands for gross domestic product and is a measurement of the total goods and services produced in a country in a year').
- ✓ You can discuss macroeconomic indicators that are not covered in Topics 1-4.
- ✓ We recommend that you divide your answers for each section into parts (a), (b) and (c) so the markers can easily see if you have answered all the questions.
- ✓ You can also answer all the questions in one single section. If you do so, make sure that you have clearly answered all the questions.
- ✓ There is no need to repeat the questions in your answer.
- ✓ You can use a single direct quote or multiple direct quotes in your report, but the total number of words of all quotes combined must be 20 words or less. Any direct quote must be properly referenced.
- ✓ Read the mistakes students tend to make: Blackboard > Assessment > Country Report > Past Common Feedback.

Tips for Section 2 Benchmarking:

- ✓ Why do we need to do benchmarking? This assignment is to advise your client about the suitability of your country as an investment destination. Your advice should depend on how favourable your country's macroeconomic conditions are relative to potential alternative investment destinations. That is why benchmarking is important. This reason should also give you some ideas about how to choose a benchmark.
- ✓ Countries that can serve as alternative investment destinations should have a similar economic system, key industries and institutions as your country.
- ✓ The largest economy or the nearest economy is not necessarily a suitable benchmark; it is about relevance.
- ✓ We recommend you divide your answer into parts (a), (b) and (c), but you are allowed to provide your answer as a single section.

Tips for Section 3 Reflection:

- ✓ This section asks you to reflect on how you worked through this assessment and, more importantly, what you have learnt from this process.
- ✓ There are no right or wrong 'reflections'. However, reflection can be deep (good!) or shallow (not so good!).
- ✓ For part (b), your answer could include your discussion with your tutor or the course coordinator if applicable.
- ✓ For part (c), your advice can be specific (e.g., how to show the relationship between variables X and Y graphically) or general (e.g., how to effectively use the Similarity Report for revision).
- ✓ This is a new section and therefore not covered in Past Common Feedback.

Tips for Section 4 References:

- ✓ Having more in-text citations and references will reduce the number of words for the main body while having too few in-text citations and references will reduce the credibility of the report. Therefore, you need to balance the two.
- ✓ Use a variety of sources (rather than just one or two) and use credible sources, e.g., WDI indicators by the World Bank, official government websites and academic journals.
- ✓ Consult UQ's referencing style guide for the APA 7th styles.
- ✓ You must reference sources that you use for your text, graphs or tables.
- ✓ You must reference a source even when you have paraphrased the original content.
- ✓ You can refer to non-English material sources only if no equivalent English sources are available, but you should keep such sources to a minimum.
- ✓ If you refer to non-English material sources, you need to provide the English-translated references with a note at the end, e.g., "(original in German)". The marker will consider the availability of English material sources for your country to ensure fairness in marking.
- ✓ You could use the EndNote program (downloadable from the UQ library) to manage your references instead of doing it manually.
- ✓ For references to data sources, you should follow the Dataset format in the UQ APA 7th style guide, e.g.,

  World Bank (2020a). *World Development Indicators. GDP (current US$)* [Data file]. https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators

  World Bank (2020b). *World Development Indicators. GDP growth (annual %)* [Data file]. https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators

DATA REQUIREMENTS

Your primary data sources should be:

a. National agencies, e.g., Statistical Bureau, Treasury, Central Bank; *or*
b. Multinational agencies, e.g., the World Bank, the United Nations, the International Monetary Fund, the European Central Bank, the Bank for International Settlements, Eurostat.

Data from secondary sources can still be used as a supplement *only if* those data are not available from any primary sources. **Using non-primary data can lead to a loss of marks when primary source data is available for your country.**

The World Bank's World Development Indicators (WDI) database contains most of the national data collected by national and multinational agencies and can be used as a primary data source. Here are some YouTube tutorials on how to extra data from the WDI:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JGJhI_YqFuI (May 7, 2019)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f_B1t4BRQ94&t=64s (Sept 21, 2018)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MKANI-ZWUTY (March 9, 2017)

Tips for Data:

- ✓ WDI data are on annual basis. If you want to use monthly or quarterly data, you need to access statistics directly from your country's statistical bureau.
- ✓ Do not falsely claim that certain data are not readily available from a primary source without doing your due diligence. For most data at the national level (e.g., GDP, unemployment rate), only national or multinational agencies have the capacity to collect those data. Therefore, it is extremely unlikely that they are available from a secondary source but not from a primary source.
- ✓ If you use data from a source (e.g., a report) that indicates that it drew the data from a government statistical bureau, the data is considered to have come from a secondary source, not a primary source. However, if you go to the government statistical bureau and extract the same data (and verify what you read is indeed accurate), then it is considered to have come from a primary source.
- ✓ **Trading Economics** (https://tradingeconomics.com) is a secondary source, not a primary source. You should not use it for your report.

SUBMITTING YOUR COUNTRY REPORT

- Check if you tick all the items on the submission checklist provided on Blackboard > Assessment > Country Report > Submission Checklist. (Note: Do not submit the checklist.)

- Your report must be submitted through ***Turnitin*** on Blackboard to check for plagiarism. While most instances of plagiarism are unintentional, any form of plagiarism (intentional or unintentional) will be revealed in the originality report.

- From the originality report, the marker will check whether any part of your report is considered as having potentially plagiarised from other sources, rather than just relying on the similarity index value. **Therefore, you are expected to carefully check the originality report before your final submission.** (Also see the Penalty section above.)

- You can resubmit your report unlimited times before the due date. However, **after three resubmissions, the similarity report is generated after 24 hours**.

- Turnitin will not provide you with a confirmation email after successful submission. However, you can download a **digital receipt as proof of submission**. UQ Library provides a guide on how to submit a Turnitin assignment, get a digital receipt, and view Similarity Report and marks.

- The time of submission is based on the time your report was successfully uploaded on Turnitin **as recorded by Turnitin**, not the time you tried to upload it.

- Many students failed to meet the deadline because they had internet connection problems on their side, but they mistook it as an IT problem of UQ. If UQ has any internet connection problems, there will be a record of it.

- The only way to guarantee not missing the deadline is to submit your report well before the deadline.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS (FAQs)

QUESTIONS	ANSWERS
Why do we need to do this assignment?	To excel in the workplace, professional economists need to be able to: ● ***analyse problems***; ● ***identify*** potential ***solutions*** and their ***limitations;*** ● ***find***, ***extract*** and ***organise*** good quality and relevant ***data***; and ● ***present findings*** precisely and concisely. This assignment aims to provide you with an opportunity to develop these skills.
Why can't I use more than three figures?	Consultant reports are typically very concise so that (busy) readers can focus on the most relevant information. As the number of figures is limited to no more than three, you need to think carefully about where to use them to maximise the overall impact of the report.
Why can't I cut and paste figures from other sources?	This is part of real-world training on how to extract and organise data and present findings.
If I want to include a graph, how should I do this?	Insert your graph as an image, rather than as an Excel object, in your report.
How should I include a diagram (e.g., an AD-AS model) in my report?	A simple way to do so is to draw it in PowerPoint, copy it, and then paste it as an image in your report.
How should I cite any data source used for a figure?	Include the data source below each figure. For example: "Source: World Bank (2020)".
Why are there so many penalties?	In the real world, a submitted document that does not follow the instructions could be rejected entirely.
Why only limited direct quotes are allowed?	Students often misuse direct quotes as a way to avoid paraphrasing.
Can I see some samples?	***No.*** Once people have seen some samples, they naturally want to copy them rather than thinking independently. However, in the tutorial, we will provide a 'bad example' to show you what could go wrong. Also, see the Past Common Feedback on Blackboard.
How do I know if I do paraphrasing and referencing correctly?	In the tutorials, we will provide exercises on how to do referencing and paraphrasing, respectively.

End of The Instruction